

Doing your own taxes is easy using tax software such as TurboTax by Intuit or TaxCut by H&R Block. You can buy the software from Staples or other office supply stores or download the program online for around \$30 for the basic version. This type of software handles both simple and complex returns with ease, although it does take a bit of time. The programs walk you through an interview process by asking you questions, do all the calculations, and produce your finished tax return and any necessary schedules, plus worksheets to keep in your file as backup. You can either print the return and mail it or file it electronically. Both federal and state versions are available.

Using Web-Based Software

If you don't want to buy new tax software every year, you can use web-based software. It's no longer significantly cheaper than buying your own, so the main advantage now to web-based software is that you don't have to be on your own PC to work on your return. You can do so from any computer that has access to the Internet. You don't have to complete your return in one sitting; you can come back to it as often as you want until you're ready to hit the "Send" button.



There are a few instances where you can't file the entire return electronically. If your return includes one of several schedules that require another person's signature—for instance, noncustodial parents claiming exemptions for their kids—you'll have to file a paper copy of the form along with transmittal Form 8453 within three business days after the IRS acknowledges it has received your electronically filed return.

Using Paper and Pen